

How to Prepare for Your First Chemotherapy Appointment

Quick Tips Care Guide



Starting chemotherapy can feel overwhelming. Knowing what to expect and preparing ahead can help you feel more comfortable, confident, and supported.

Before Your Appointment

Talk with your care team

- Ask how long your treatment will take
- Ask which medicines you will receive
- Ask about common side effects and how to manage them
- Write down your questions before your visit

Take care of dental and medical needs

- Tell your regular doctors and dentist that you are starting chemotherapy
- Take care of any dental problems before treatment, if possible
- Ask about preventing mouth sores before your first infusion

Plan ahead

- Confirm your appointment time and location
- Bring your insurance card and photo ID
- Arrange a ride home if needed
- Plan for help with work, childcare, or meals

Get your body ready

- Drink plenty of water the day before and the morning of treatment, unless told otherwise
- Eat a light meal before your appointment unless your doctor says not to
- Try bland foods if you feel nervous, such as toast, oatmeal, bananas, or crackers
- Get a good night's sleep

What to Bring

Pack a small bag with

- Water bottle
- Light snacks
- List of current medicines and allergies
- Notebook and pen
- Phone and headphones
- Lip balm or unscented lotion
- Blanket or sweater, since treatment rooms can feel cold
- Copy of your treatment plan and emergency contacts

During Your Appointment

- Your first visit may take longer than future visits
- Nurses may monitor you closely during treatment
- You may receive medicines to help prevent nausea or other side effects
- Let your nurse know right away if you feel pain, burning, dizziness, chills, nausea, or anything unusual

Helpful Habits

- Eat small meals more often if your stomach feels unsettled
- Keep a simple journal of food, symptoms, and questions
- Stay in touch with family, friends, or a support person
- Practice deep breathing, prayer, meditation, or quiet relaxation
- Accept help when it is offered

What to Wear

- Comfortable, loose-fitting clothes
- Layers, in case you get cold
- A shirt with sleeves that roll up easily for IV access

After Your Appointment

- You may stay for a short observation period before going home
- Make sure you leave with:
 - Your next appointment dates
 - Important phone numbers
 - Instructions for side effects and when to call
- Ask how much water you should drink after treatment
- Rest if you feel tired

Common Questions

How long will my first chemo appointment take?

It may take several hours, depending on your treatment plan.

Will I feel sick right away?

Not always. Some side effects happen later the same day or the next day.

Should I eat before treatment?

Usually yes, unless your doctor tells you not to.

Can I work afterward?

Some people can, but many prefer to rest after their first treatment.

Avoid These Common Mistakes

- Arriving dehydrated
- Skipping meals unless instructed to fast
- Wearing tight or uncomfortable clothing
- Forgetting medicines, snacks, or paperwork
- Going without support if you feel anxious

7-Day Preparation Checklist

A week before treatment:

- Learn about your treatment
- Write down questions
- Buy easy-to-eat foods and snacks
- Arrange transportation and help at home
- Pack your treatment bag
- Try a relaxation app or calming routine
- Confirm appointment details the night before

On treatment day:

- Eat a light meal
- Dress comfortably
- Bring your bag
- Take a deep breath and ask questions when needed

Remember

You do not have to do this alone. Small steps can make your first chemotherapy appointment feel more manageable. Preparing ahead can help you feel more in control and more supported.

References

[National Leiomyosarcoma Foundation](#)

[Very Well Health Guide](#)



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